

80% Likable. 20% Technical. Always.

Visual reference cards from the Friday 15 May session led by director Corie Dawson. Use alongside the Session 1–6 toolkits. Print, pin to your wall, or keep on your desk.

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Print and pin. Read every morning.

The 80/20 likability rule

A 100% technical pitch leaves zero room for error. An 80/20 likable pitch is the insurance policy that lets every other technique survive small mistakes.

100% TECHNICAL

no room for error

100%
TECHNICAL

80/20 LIKABILITY

room to manoeuvre

80%
LIKABLE

20%
TECH

WHY 80/20 BEATS 100/0

- 100% technical means any small mistake (wrong number, awkward pause, ill-judged comment) is fatal — there's no goodwill to absorb it.
- 80% likable means the prospect is already invested in YOU as a person, so small product mistakes are forgiven, not amplified.
- Connection compresses the rest of the sale: objections soften, follow-ups get answered, price becomes a conversation.
- Most of the time, a likable rep with 70% of the product knowledge will out-close a technical rep with 100%.

THE PRINCIPLE

"If you're likable, there's a higher chance they'll trust you. If you're not likable, there's more chance they won't."

The five ingredients of a relationship

Every relationship — personal, professional, romantic, transactional — is built from five ingredients. New prospects have zero of the first one.

TIME

THE FLOUR

The bulk. Most long relationships rely on this. New prospects have none of it — so don't lean here.

CARE

THE EGGS

What binds everything. Without care, the rest falls apart. Care is what new-relationship trust is built from.

EXPERIENCES

THE SALT

Shared moments — good or bad — that make a relationship distinct. Create one in your first meeting.

SHARING IDEAS

CONVERSATION

Back-and-forth dialogue. Real exchange, not one-sided extraction. Texture.

GIVING

GENEROSITY

Physical items, attention, thoughts, effort. Small acts of giving compound fast.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR NEW PROSPECTS

In a new sales relationship you have ZERO time. So you can't rely on time-built trust. Compensate by overloading the other four — care, experiences, sharing, giving. A 30-minute meeting with real care can feel as connected as 18 months of average treatment.

The three locking mechanisms of every sale

Every sale is a lock with three pins. All three have to release for the deal to open. Two are out of your control. One isn't.

LOCK 1

AFFORDABILITY

Do they have the money?

Vet BEFORE the meeting using the affordability formula. If math says no, the meeting is already lost.

OUT OF YOUR CONTROL once meeting starts.

LOCK 2

INTENT

Do they want to buy?

Vet EARLY in the meeting using the scale-up / wind-down question. If intent is missing, no amount of pitch fixes it.

OUT OF YOUR CONTROL once intent is established.

LOCK 3

LIKABILITY

Do they like you?

The only lock you can pick. The only mechanism you fully control. Where almost all your effort should go.

100% UNDER YOUR CONTROL — every meeting, every word, every gesture.

THE LESSON

Two of the three locks are vetting work — done before, or in the first minutes of, the meeting. The rest of the conversation is Lock 3. Almost every closing failure where the math worked traces back to a likability gap.

The one line that vets intent fastest

Lock 2 (intent) needs to be checked before significant pitch energy. One question. Four possible answers. Each one tells you exactly what to do.

THE VETTING QUESTION

“If you don’t mind me asking — over the next few years, are you looking to scale this up, or are you thinking more about winding it down?”

HOW TO READ EACH ANSWER

THEY SAY

“Scaling up — looking to grow.”

YOU DO

Pitch hard. Position your service as a growth lever. Everything is open.

THEY SAY

“Happy at this size. Maintaining.”

YOU DO

Reframe as protection / maintenance. Don’t pitch growth — they’ll resist.

THEY SAY

“Winding down. Maybe two more years.”

YOU DO

Reposition as sale prep. Website as an asset to be sold. Or step back gracefully.

THEY SAY

“Not sure — depends on the market.”

YOU DO

Cautious read. Pitch a smaller package with a clean exit. Don’t go big.

WHY ONE QUESTION IS ENOUGH

The scale-up / wind-down framing forces the prospect onto a binary they can’t politely dodge. The answer they give shapes the rest of the call — and saves you from pitching the wrong package.

Asymmetric bets — language that can only help

Some questions build connection no matter how the prospect answers. Use these. They're the lowest-risk, highest-reward lines in your kit.

THE MODEL PHRASE

“That must be a hard job.”

IF THEY AGREE

THEY SAY

“Yeah, it's relentless. People don't understand.”

WHAT YOU GET

They unload challenges. You learn what they're fighting against.

CONNECTION BUILT THROUGH

Shared empathy. “I can imagine.”

IF THEY DISAGREE

THEY SAY

“No, I actually love it. Best decision I ever made.”

WHAT YOU GET

They tell you what they love. You learn their motivation.

CONNECTION BUILT THROUGH

Shared enthusiasm. “That's wonderful — what's the best part?”

MORE ASYMMETRIC OPENERS

- “How did you end up in this industry?” — origin stories build connection.
- “What's the biggest challenge in your business right now?” — vents or pivots to confidence.
- “What's the best part of your week, usually?” — positive even when they're busy.
- “You've obviously been doing this a while — what's the secret?” — flattering, invites teaching.

AVOID SYMMETRIC BETS

Don't open with an opinion the prospect might disagree with. “I bet teaching's easy these days” is a symmetric bet — wrong half the time, catastrophic when wrong.

Recognising “the speech”

When a prospect likes you but can't close, they deliver a long, warm, off-topic monologue. Spotting it stops you wasting weeks on a deal that was never closeable.

WHAT THE SPEECH SOUNDS LIKE

“You're a really nice guy. You actually remind me of my nephew. I should tell you — we're taking a cruise next month, the dog's having a heart operation, the neighbour's cat lost its tail in our yard — but anyway, definitely give me a call next year, I really think we should do this together ...”

WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS

“I like you enough to be polite — but I can't actually buy from you right now.” Lock 3 (likability) opened. Lock 1 (affordability) or Lock 2 (intent) is shut. The lesson is upstream: better qualification BEFORE the meeting.

WHAT TO DO

Don't fight it. Don't lower the price. Don't try harder. The locks that need to open simply aren't available right now. Bank the likability for next year.

Try: “Honestly, thanks so much — I really appreciate it. I'll keep your details and reach out properly when the timing's right.”

THE REFRAME

The speech isn't a failure — it's confirmation you're likable. The failure was earlier: you didn't vet affordability or intent before booking the meeting.

Likability creates buyer-side ransom

When you're likable enough, the prospect feels they HAVE to buy from you. They will defend that decision against cheaper alternatives. Connection compounds.

A TRUE STORY (PARAPHRASED)

Two car dealers. One in the city — condescending, sloppy follow-up, treated the customer like an inconvenience. One in a small country town 200 km away — talked about fishing, knew the same beach, joked about modifications, never pressured. Same customer, same vehicle category.

CITY DEALER

OUTCOME

Lost the first sale. Lost the second sale. Lost every future sale.

CUSTOMER'S STANCE

Permanent no-buy. Even at any future discount.

WHY

Single condescending interaction — lifetime ban.

LESSON

Lost likability is permanent. One bad call kills decades of potential business.

COUNTRY DEALER

OUTCOME

First sale closed in one call. Second sale automatic. 200 km is no obstacle.

CUSTOMER'S STANCE

Will defend the buying decision against cheaper alternatives.

WHY

Connection compresses the rest of the sale. Price softens. Trust extends.

LESSON

Likability is the only lever where every unit invested compounds for years.

THE PRINCIPLE

When you're likable enough, you're not selling — they're buying. And they will defend the decision to buy from you because they don't want to lose YOU. Not the deal. You.

Daily mindset card

Read every morning before your first call. Print this page. Pin it to your monitor.

TODAY'S MANTRA

80% likable. 20% technical.

LIKABLE

Lead with likability on every call. The product knowledge is the easy part. The connection is the lever.

VET FIRST

Affordability before the meeting. Intent in the first five minutes. Likability the rest of the call.

ASYMMETRIC

"That must be a hard job." Use language that builds connection no matter how they answer.

NO MINES

Religion, politics, money. Avoid all three with new prospects. The downside isn't worth the gamble.

LONG CARE

Refresh care with long-term clients. Treat your three best clients like it's the first week.

When you're likable enough, you're not selling. They're buying.

— Corie Dawson